

What else to watch: *Ninotchka* (1939) ■ *How to Marry a Millionaire* (1953) ■ *Sabrina* (1954) ■ *The Prince and the Showgirl* (1957) ■ *The Apartment* (1960) ■ *Irma la Duce* (1963) ■ *The Fortune Cookie* (1966) ■ *Tootsie* (1982)



While Joe cavorts with Sugar on a yacht—in Curtis's memorable spoof of Cary Grant—the dress-wearing, tango-dancing, but decidedly heterosexual Jerry gets engaged to an aging but genuine millionaire, Osgood (Joe E. Brown). “You’re a guy! Why would a guy want to marry a guy?” asks Joe when he finds out. “Security!” replies Jerry, without missing a beat, his eyes moony at the thought of all that cash.

In the end, Jerry drops the act and tells Osgood the truth. “I’m a man!” he admits with a growl. But Osgood isn’t bothered. “Nobody’s perfect!” he beams, and Jerry shoots the camera a “Well, whaddyaknow?” look as the movie fades out.

In *Some Like It Hot*, everybody is desperate to get their hands on something, and in Marilyn Monroe the movie has the most lusted-after star in Hollywood history—“Like Jell-O on springs!” is how Jerry

As “Josephine” and “Daphne”, Joe and Jerry hope to blend in with Sweet Sue and her Society Syncopators on a night train to Florida, but there’s no mistaking who plays the ukulele.

describes her body. Yet Monroe’s performance delivers something truly magical. In one scene, during a lull in the action, Monroe sings *I Wanna Be Loved By You* straight into the camera: she’s seductive, sweet, and wistful all at once, and she succeeds in transforming Sugar’s cynicism into a childlike vulnerability. When she kisses Joe on the yacht, he is transformed, too—from seducer to seduced.

Flaws and frailty

Some Like It Hot reputedly suffered from behind-the-scenes tensions. Monroe was initially unhappy with being filmed in period-style black and white, and Curtis famously said that kissing Monroe was “like kissing Hitler.” Whether the actor meant it or not, this illusion-shattering jibe echoes Wilder’s great preoccupation with human flaws and frailties. Nobody’s perfect, it seems—not even the legendary Marilyn Monroe. ■



Jack Lemmon Actor

“Magic time” was how Jack Lemmon (1925–2001)

described acting. He would mutter this phrase to himself before stepping onto a stage or in front of a camera. Lemmon worked in television and light entertainment before finding his feet in movies, where his everyman qualities made him

a star. He was often one half of a double act; key collaborators included zany comedian Ernie Kovacs, actor Walter Matthau, and filmmaker Billy Wilder.

Key movies

1959 *Some Like It Hot*
1960 *The Apartment*
1968 *The Odd Couple*
1992 *Glengarry Glen Ross*